BSRM X ALDO RETAIL GEN AI HACKATHON

OVERVIEW

FALL 2026

RETAIL GEN_AI HACKATH<>N

In partnership with ALDO GROUP

McGill | École Bensadoun de commerce au détail Bensadoun School of Retail Management

powered by aws

DATA SPHERE LAB

WELCOME TO THE 2026 ALDO X BSRM RETAIL GEN AI HACKATHON

POWERED BY AWS & THE DATA SPHERE LAB

THEME: Rethinking returns with agentic AI

Based on the use case provided by ALDO Group, in Phase 1 , your team will explain the proposed solution and develop a live demo in the Live Final Phase.

FRAMING:

Data policy: Organizers will not share proprietary data. Teams must use public datasets and/or synthetic data they generate. Keep datasets small but sufficient to demonstrate behavior. Respect ToS; no scraping behind logins.

Agentic expectation: Show autonomous loops (plan → tool calls → observe → reflect → next action), plus safety checks and grounded explanations (cite the source row/field, doc, or rule).

AWS Platforms: Amazon Bedrock, Strands Agents SDK, Lambda, etc. AWS Mentors will be available to coach how to best use AWS tools.

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HACKATHON PHASES

PHASE 1 IDEATION

VIRTUAL : SEPTEMBER 23 TO OCTOBER 4

LIVE FINAL HACKATHON

OCTOBER 15TH & 16TH: WITH ALDO GROUP AND AWS MENTORS FOR 10 FINALIST TEAMS

FINAL PRESENTATION

OCTOBER 16TH AFTERNOON: PITCH YOUR FINAL PROPOSAL IN 8 MINUTES WITH PROTOTYPE BEFORE A JURY PANEL

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IDEATION:

🗓️ **September 23rd to October 4th**

🚀 **Wednesday, September 23rd : LAUNCH**

Kick off the Ideation . Read the Phase 1 Instructions and the criteria by which you'll be judged.

📆 **AWS Expert-Led Training Workshop.**
Virtual workshop.
Wednesday September 30th 5:30PM – 6:30PM

⏰ **Sunday October 4th - 4 PM EST**
IDEATION DEADLINE

Time's up! Make sure to submit your Ideation proposal.

🏅 **Friday October 9th - 6 PM EST**
FINALIST REVEAL

We'll announce the Top 10 finalist teams via email, chosen based on our predefined criteria.

LIVE HACKATHON FINAL:

🗓️ **Thursday, October 15th**

🍳 10:00 AM - Kickoff & Swag:

Start your day with a welcome breakfast and get your hackathon SWAG.

👩‍💻👨‍💻 HACKING COMMENCES

After a quick rundown of the hackathon guidelines, dive right into hacking in your designated areas on 2nd floor of Bronfman Bldg.

🌐 AWS Access and Mentoring

Each finalist team receives AWS access, and ALDO & AWS experts/mentors are available for consultation.

🍱 12 PM - Fuel Up:

Lunch boxes and beverages are available for all finalist teams.

🎤 Check in with Mentors 3:30 PM

Don't miss the chance to make sure you are on track

🍕 5 PM - Recharge:

Take a break with pizza and refreshments, then get back to finalizing your transformative solutions. Building closes at 9PM.

FINAL SHOWCASE:

🗓️ **Friday October 16th**

🍳 Morning (8AM) - Hack to the Finish Line:

Enjoy breakfast and keep working!

👩‍💻👨‍💻 MENTOR CHECK IN: morning

Receive valuable insights during check-ins with mentors from the ALDO Team and AWS mentors

🍱 12 PM - Sustain & Maintain:

Lunch boxes and beverages are at the ready for all finalist teams.

11: 00 AM – 2:30 PM – TEST YOUR DEMO & PRACTICE

⏰ 2 PM – HACKING CONCLUDES

Keyboards down! Prepare for the final presentations.

🎙️ **2: 30 PM – 4:30 PM – JUDGEMENT HOUR:**

Present your solutions to an expert jury panel.
Make it count!

🏆 5 PM – 6 PM - The Grand Finale:

Winner Announcements & Prize Ceremony: See if your team takes home the glory!
Closing Cocktail & Appetizers: Let's toast to innovation and collaborative brilliance!

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  $3000
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